Sales Training Debrief — Session 22

Genuine Stall vs Smoke. The Reversible Yes.

Sales training led by Corie Dawson, Director · Tuesday 2 June 2026 · Marketing Sweet

1. The case — a real stall in front of a real deal

The session opened with a live debrief of a deal in progress. The prospect: a Gold Coast cabinet-making and kitchen-renovation business, seven years old, twelve staff, ~$3.6M turnover, ~$1M profit. The rep had built a strong pitch — the prospect rated the call 8 or 9 out of 10 and explicitly said the only thing stopping a 10 was choosing between two payment options. The buyer asked the rep to call back on Wednesday because (a) they were meeting their accountant on Tuesday, and (b) Monday was going to be a write-off due to a staff member's personal emergency.

The question the rep brought to training: do I leave it until Wednesday, or do I push earlier? The answer turned into the whole session — because the answer hinges on distinguishing a genuine stall from a smokescreen.

2. Genuine stall vs smoke — how to tell the difference

Buyers stall for two completely different reasons. A genuine stall is a real-world constraint: an accountant meeting, a partner who needs to weigh in, a family emergency, a holiday. A smokescreen is a polite delay manufactured to end the conversation without saying no. Treating both the same way costs the rep — they either push too hard on a genuine stall and damage the relationship, or they accept the smoke and write off a deal that was already gone.

The distinguishing signals:

GENUINE STALL	SMOKESCREEN
Specific reason with personal/operational detail	Vague reason, generic timing
Names a real third party (accountant, partner)	References an unnamed "someone"
Booked-in callback date and time	"I'll get back to you" — no fixed time
Buyer initiates the next step	Rep has to initiate every time
Energy stays warm; engagement is still there	Energy goes flat; engagement collapses
Buyer asks follow-up questions	Buyer stops asking questions

> *"Someone died, so he's telling you that sort of personal information. That means it's a genuine stall — there's not much you can do but pitch it well and wait."*

3. The diagnostic question — "just out of interest, which one?"

Before the rep agrees to wait until Wednesday, there’s a single low-pressure question that surfaces the buyer’s real preference. The question is framed as casual interest, not as a sales push — "just out of interest" is the disarming opener that gives the buyer permission to share without feeling cornered.

> *"Just out of interest — which one are you more likely to go for?"*

Why this question matters:

- It surfaces the buyer’s lean before they leave the call. If they’re already pointing at the up-front option, the rep knows where to push next.
- It’s low-stakes. The buyer can answer honestly without committing. "Just out of interest" frames it as informal.
- It gives the rep a foundation for the next move. Without this answer, the rep has to guess. With it, the rep knows whether to mirror the up-front path or the monthly path.

In the cabinet-maker case, the buyer answered: "I’m leaning toward up-front — it’s not that much money for me, but I want to see what the accountant says." That answer is the entire opening for the next move.

4. Mirror the preference, offer to start

Once the buyer states a preference, the rep doesn’t politely set it aside and wait until Wednesday. The rep mirrors the preference back, frames it as a sensible choice, and offers a way to start moving without locking the buyer into anything.

> *"I’d just go up-front. Why don’t we get a small deposit, and we can swap it out if you change your mind? It’s the same product either way."*

The structure of the mirror-and-advance:

1. Acknowledge the preference the buyer just stated. "I’d go up-front too, honestly."
2. Validate the reasoning. "You spend $2,000 a month on the other crew — this is only $5,000 once."
3. Offer the reversible path. "Why don’t we get a small deposit down to get the ball rolling?"
4. Remove the lock-in fear. "If you change your mind after the accountant call, we’ll just swap it out — same product either way."

5. The reversible yes — the closing move that defuses risk

The central technique of the session. Most buyers who hesitate aren’t hesitating about the product or the price — they’re hesitating about commitment. They don’t want to lock in something they can’t change. The reversible yes removes that fear by offering a path forward that can be undone if the buyer changes their mind.

Why this works structurally:

- Reversibility lowers the perceived cost of saying yes. The buyer is not choosing forever — they're choosing the next step.
- It transfers momentum. Once a small deposit is in, the deal is moving. The default direction is now forward, not stalled.
- It still tests legitimacy. A buyer with a genuine stall will often take the reversible yes, because the only barrier was the lock-in. A buyer with smoke won't — because they were never going to buy at all.

THE TEST If you offer the reversible yes and the buyer still wants to wait — that's smoke. If they take the deposit, they were going to buy regardless. Either answer is useful.

6. Smoke detection — what the reversible yes reveals

The reversible-yes move is also a diagnostic. When a buyer's objection is removed — "you can change it later, same product, just $500 to start" — and they still find a reason to delay, the rep now knows the objection was never the real one. The rep doesn't need to chase the new reason. They've got their answer.

> *"If he still said he needed to speak to his accountant after that, you'd know it's not a genuine reason. Because you can swap it. There's nothing to wait for."*

How to read the reaction:

- Buyer takes the deposit → genuine interest, deal moves forward.
- Buyer enthusiastically agrees but "will sort it tomorrow" → soft smoke, follow up tomorrow but expect attrition.
- Buyer finds a new reason to delay despite the reversibility → hard smoke, deal was never going to close at this price/now.
- Buyer asks a fresh genuine question about the deposit mechanics → still real, just needs information.

7. Listening to concerns — and addressing them individually

The session's underlying skill, beneath all the moves above: the rep has to actually listen. The cabinet-maker case worked because the rep heard two distinct concerns from the buyer — the accountant question (real, about advice) and the timing question (real, about Monday being a write-off). The rep didn't conflate them into one big "the buyer is hesitant." That separation is what made the diagnostic question possible.

The listening discipline:

- When a buyer voices a concern, name it back to them. "So the accountant question is about which payment structure makes sense from your books?"
- Resist the urge to answer the concern before you've confirmed you understood it. Wrong-target answers reveal the rep wasn't listening.
- Handle each concern in turn. Buyers don't list their concerns in one go — they reveal them as the rep moves through the call.
- Where concerns are genuine, accept them. Where they're smoke, test them with the reversible-yes move.

> *"It's all about listening to their concerns and addressing each one to find out whether it's genuine. If it's not genuine and you've offered every reasonable path — that's smoke. And where there's smoke, there's fire."*

8. Where this connects to urgency

This session is the practical application of the urgency principle established earlier. Urgency is not about pressuring every buyer to commit today — it's about moving fast on the buyers who are ready to move, and identifying fast which buyers aren't. The reversible yes lets the rep do both at once.

Putting it together:

- Surface the lean with the diagnostic question ("just out of interest, which one?").
- If the buyer has a lean, mirror it and offer the reversible path.
- Take the deposit if it's real. Get smoke detection if it's not. Either way, the rep's time is no longer trapped in ambiguity.
- If it's a genuine stall, accept the booked-in callback and apply urgency to that conversation when it happens.

9. Action items this week

5. On every stalled deal this week, ask the diagnostic question: "just out of interest, which option are you more likely to go for?"
6. When a buyer states a preference, mirror it back. Don't politely set it aside.
7. Practise the reversible-yes opener: "why don't we get a small deposit down — same product, we can swap it out if you change your mind."
8. Audit your last five stalls. Were they genuine or smoke? Which signals did you miss?
9. When a buyer names a specific personal or operational reason, accept it. Apply urgency to the booked-in callback, not the present moment.
10. When a buyer says "I'll get back to you" with no time and no reason, treat that as smoke until proven otherwise — and test it with a reversible offer before the call ends.

THE ONE-LINER Real stalls have specific reasons and booked-in callbacks. Smoke has neither. The reversible yes tells you which is which — and moves the real ones forward today.